Do mammals have “brains wired for infidelity”?

BRAIN & EVOLUTION

The answer is not that simple.
Humans can feel sexual or romantic attraction to someone else even while attached to a particular partner.
However, mating and pair formation vary greatly among mammal species.

First, distinguish these ideas

“Feeling attraction” and “being unfaithful” are different.
Infidelity is a concept tied to human marriage and social norms.

Sexual desire, romantic feelings and attachment do not fully coincide

DESIRE / ROMANCE / ATTACHMENT

01 | Sexual desire

Motivation to seek sexual involvement.

02 | Romantic feelings

Strong attraction to and longing for a particular person.

03 | Attachment

A sense of security with a partner and a lasting bond.
These interact but are not the same. Attachment does not necessarily eliminate all attraction to others.

Why can we be attracted to multiple partners?

EVOLUTION

From an evolutionary perspective, mating with several partners can sometimes create opportunities to leave offspring.
On the other hand, a lasting relationship with a partner can sometimes benefit child rearing and survival.

Two tendencies can coexist

Sexual interest in multiple partners.
A lasting bond with a particular partner.
This explanation does not apply to every species or individual. Evolution alone does not determine individual behavior.

Attraction and actual behavior are different

IMPULSE & ACTION

Impulse and emotion

You may feel attracted to another person.

Attachment

Build a lasting relationship with a particular partner.

Judgment and norms

Choose actions in light of values and commitments.
“Feeling attracted” does not justify behavior. Humans can choose by considering not only impulses, but care for their partner, promises, social norms and the consequences of their actions.